The Case for Calling Mississippi

By Benjamin Rouan

Mississippi U.S. Senate 2026 · Scott Colom (D) v. Cindy Hyde-Smith (R) v. Ty Pinkins (I) ·
Figures as of Friday, Nov. 6, 2026, 6:45 PM CST · Independent analysis

Thesis: Scott Colom's lead cannot be overcome by the ballots that remain. The race is callable now.

Colom leads by 2,574 votes on AP's count,[24] and by 2,821 once county-published batches that AP has not yet loaded are included (Section 1).[21,22,23,25] AP's own expected-vote figures put about 30,300 votes still out.[24] For Hyde-Smith to win, those votes would have to break 54% her way (Section 5). Four independent lines of evidence say they will not, and most say they will do the opposite:

1. **AP's own remainder favors Colom.** Apply each county's current vote share to AP's county-by-county estimate of what is left, with no adjustment for ballot type, and add about 3,850 absentees in Hancock, Monroe and Tippah that the county documents show as not yet counted and AP's estimate leaves out (turnout suggests some or all may already be in; the report counts them anyway, the cautious choice, since they favor Hyde-Smith), plus mail the counties have received since Nov. 2 but not yet counted. The remaining vote still nets Colom about **+2,100**, for a final lead of about 4,700 (Section 2).[24,29] Cut Hinds County's remainder to about 2,000, as the county's own records suggest,[3,4,7] and Colom still finishes about **2,350 votes ahead**, even with no affidavit lean at all. The county-by-county simulation, which uses the counties' own figures and the measured affidavit lean, gives Colom better than a 99.9% chance of winning (Section 5).
2. **Affidavit ballots are breaking for Colom everywhere.** Fifteen counties have added post-election batches (Section 3).[13,14,15,16,21,23,24,25] In every one, Colom beat his own share of that county's vote, by 4 to 30 points. The ten confirmed affidavit batches split 65%–35% for Colom. That includes counties Trump carried by 50 points.[16]

3. **Late mail is too small to matter, counting both kinds.** *Not yet returned:* 2,857 mail ballots statewide (Secretary of State, Nov. 6).[1] Few arrive in the five-day window: Hinds counted 18 late mail ballots against 1,093 unreturned in 2024.[4,27] If a quarter arrived and every one went to Hyde-Smith, she would net about 700. *Already received but not yet counted:* the Secretary of State's figure counts only ballots that still "must be received,"[31] so ballots sitting in clerks' offices are not in it. Jackson has 280 and Rankin 282, per their circuit clerks,[10,12] and Hinds is processing mail received after Election Day.[6] Statewide, unreturned ballots fell from 6,587 on Nov. 2 to 2,857,[1,8] so up to about 3,700 arrived, some already counted. They can only come from counties that had ballots out on Nov. 2. Even if every one came from the most Republican of those counties and split like its vote, Hyde-Smith would net about 600. Both worst cases together, with Harrison's uncounted on-time mail added, come to about 1,350, half the lead (Section 4).
4. **Hinds County can only widen the margin.** AP shows Hinds at 93% reporting, about 5,800 votes out, in a county Colom leads 80%–19%.[24] The county's precinct data indicate its absentees were already counted,[3,4] and the commissioners' own district counts put the true remainder at roughly 1,500–2,500, nearly all affidavits.[7] If AP's figure is right instead, Colom's final margin grows to about 1.1–1.2 points (Section 6f). Either way, the uncertainty in Hinds is only about how large Colom's win is.

A simulation of every outstanding pool, county by county (Section 5), gives Colom better than a 99.9% chance of winning. Even with affidavit lean set to zero, so that every remaining ballot votes exactly like its county, he wins in 99.7% of runs, and in more than 99.9% if the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees turn out to be already counted. Hyde-Smith wins only if remaining affidavit voters are substantially *more Republican* than their own counties, the reverse of every batch reported so far (Section 5).

1. Where the count stands

Source	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Total	Colom lead
AP	467,930	465,356	20,028	953,314	+2,574 (+0.27 pt)
Decision Desk HQ	468,339	465,643	20,043	954,025	+2,696 (+0.28 pt)
Most complete count (see below)	**468,485**	**465,664**	**20,044**	**954,193**	**+2,821 (+0.30 pt)**

AP results feed[24] and Decision Desk HQ results feed,[25] read 6:45 PM CST Nov. 6.

The most complete count

The two feeds load county batches at different times. The "most complete" row takes, for each of the 82 counties, whichever of AP, DDHQ or the county's own published figures

reports the most ballots. It differs from AP in five counties:

County	Figure used	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	AP shows	Net v. AP	Source
Lowndes	DDHQ, confirmed by county records	12,553	9,006	243	12,211 / 8,834 / 239	C +170	Note a[21,25]
Chickasaw	DDHQ; MFP county report	3,462	2,894	87	3,381 / 2,871 / 86	C +58	Note b[16,25]
Washington	County election commission	8,722	2,382	163	8,660 / 2,369 / 162	C +49	Note c[22]
Tippah	DDHQ; county affidavit tally	1,862	5,409	171	1,823 / 5,378 / 171	C +8	Note d[23,25]
George	DDHQ	1,138	5,475	256	1,107 / 5,406 / 246	H +38	Note e[25]
Net difference v. AP						**C +247**	

- **a. Lowndes:** DDHQ feed, batches of Nov. 4–5 and Nov. 6, 4:23 PM CST.[25] The combined affidavit total (Colom 342, Hyde-Smith 172, Pinkins 4) matches the county's affidavit records shown on video by Abiola Agoro, who obtained them in person (X, Nov. 6, 4:05 PM CST).[21] The county reported "more than 550" affidavits cast (Deputy Circuit Clerk Ann Marie Higgins, Commercial Dispatch, Nov. 4).[21]
- **b. Chickasaw:** Mississippi Free Press, Nov. 6, 12:40 PM CST: 204 affidavits cast, 105 accepted, Colom 81, Hyde-Smith 23, Pinkins 1.[16] DDHQ loaded the same batch at 4:01 PM CST.[25]
- **c. Washington:** Delta Democrat-Times, Nov. 4, 10:10 AM CST, "unofficial results from the Washington County Election Commission," all 19 precincts.[22] Neither feed has loaded the commission's figures.
- **d. Tippah:** county affidavit tally, 147 cast, 71 accepted, Colom 39, Hyde-Smith 31.[23] DDHQ loaded the batch Nov. 6; AP has not.[25]
- **e. George:** DDHQ feed, Nov. 6, 6:41 PM CST; unlabelled batch of 110 (Colom 31, Hyde-Smith 69, Pinkins 10).[25]

Every other county matches AP exactly, or AP already carries the larger figure. Where AP and DDHQ differed earlier today on Oktibbeha, Pike, Marion, Benton, Scott, Holmes, Wilkinson and Choctaw, both have now loaded the same batches.

2. AP's own remainder, at today's county leans

AP's expected-vote parameters total 983,599, so about 30,285 remain.[24] The table applies each county's current two-party share to AP's remaining votes for that county. This assumes nothing about affidavits: it treats every remaining ballot as if it votes like the county already has. County shares are from the AP feed.[24]

County	AP votes remaining	Colom share of county vote	Net from remaining votes, at county lean
Hinds	5,831	80.8%	Colom +3,545
Lee	2,777	41.0%	Hyde-Smith +488
Rankin	2,195	36.9%	Hyde-Smith +562
DeSoto	2,140	53.1%	Colom +131
Madison	2,042	50.4%	Colom +16
Harrison	2,008	48.1%	Hyde-Smith +74
Jackson	1,551	42.5%	Hyde-Smith +227
All other counties	11,741	—	Colom +930
AP remainder, statewide	**30,285**		**Colom +3,271**
Plus absentees the county documents show as uncounted, missing from AP's estimate (may already be counted; see below): Hancock 1,798, Monroe 1,343, Tippah 718[8,29]	3,859	28.4% / 43.2% / 25.3%	Hyde-Smith +1,269
Plus mail already received but not yet counted, outside Hinds (estimate; Section 4b)[8,10,12]	1,630–2,710	county shares	Colom +80 to +140
Statewide, adjusted	**35,770–36,850**		**Colom +2,080 to +2,140**

AP's estimate shows almost nothing left in three counties whose own documents indicate their absentees have not yet been counted: Hancock (election-night summary equal to the sum of its 26 Election Day precinct reports), Monroe (summary headed "No Affidavit or Absentee Ballots") and Tippah (absentees reported pending).[23,29] The Secretary of State's Nov. 2 report shows 1,798, 1,343 and 718 absentees received in those counties.[8] Adding them at county leans, the remaining vote still widens Colom's lead by about 2,000.

A check that points the other way. Turnout in these three counties is already high without those absentees. Against each county's 2024 presidential vote, Hancock stands at 79.0%, Monroe at 79.4% and Tippah at 76.9%, at or above the highest of the counties with a similar Hyde-Smith share (highest: 78.5%, 81.6% and 73.9%; medians 71.2%, 75.1% and 70.6%).[24,28] Adding the absentees would put them at 87.5%, 87.8% and 84.3%, well above every similar county. So some or all of these ballots may already be in the count, for example if the counties tallied absentees inside their precinct totals this year. The documents and the turnout disagree, and nothing published settles it. This report counts the absentees as still to come, which costs Colom about 1,270 votes in the table. If they are already counted, his final lead is about 1,270 larger (next table).

The received-mail row covers ballots that arrived after the Secretary of State's Nov. 2 report and are still uncounted, spread like the Nov. 2 unreturned ballots and split at county shares. Hinds' share is left out because it sits inside the Hinds remainder above. AP's remainder may already expect some of these ballots in counties below 99% reporting, so this row may count a little twice; it is small either way. Harrison's mail is not in it: see Section 4b.

What that means for the race

The table above shows only how the *remaining* votes would split. Adding that to Colom's current 2,574-vote lead on AP[24] gives his final margin:

Scenario (every remaining ballot votes exactly like its county)	Net from remaining votes	Colom's final lead
AP's remainder as published	Colom +3,271	**Colom +5,845**
Adding the absentees the county documents show as uncounted, and received mail not yet counted	Colom +2,080 to +2,140	**Colom +4,660 to +4,710**
Same, with Hinds' remainder cut to 2,000 (closer to the county's records)	Hyde-Smith +190 to +250	**Colom +2,330 to +2,380**
Second row again, if the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees are already counted	Colom +3,350 to +3,410	**Colom +5,920 to +5,980**

Even the harshest combination here, the smallest Hinds remainder and no affidavit lean at all, leaves Colom ahead by more than 2,000 votes. All these rows also understate him, because they give every remaining ballot exactly its county's lean; every one of the 15 affidavit batches reported so far ran more Colom than its county (Section 3). The full simulation in Section 5 uses the county's own Hinds figures, the in-hand absentees, the received late mail and the measured affidavit lean, and gives Colom better than a 99.9% chance of winning.

3. Affidavit ballots are breaking for Colom, including in Republican counties

Most of what remains is affidavit (provisional) ballots. The Secretary of State reported 11,202 processed statewide by Friday afternoon, 8,717 accepted (78%) and 2,485 rejected,[1] up from 6,936 processed Thursday night.[2] For every county that has added affidavits, the table compares Colom's share of the county's regular vote with his share of its affidavits.

County	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Colom share, county vote	Colom share, affidavits	Difference	Net	Source
Oktibbeha	401	96	5	60.7%	80.7%	+20.0	C +305	County PDF[13]
Lowndes	342	172	4	58.0%	66.5%	+8.5	C +170	DDHQ; county documents[21,25]
Pike	159	59	2	58.7%	72.9%	+14.2	C +100	County PDF[14]
Lafayette	142	60	5	50.4%	70.3%	+19.9	C +82	County PDF; MFP[15]
Chickasaw	81	23	1	54.1%	77.9%	+23.8	C +58	MFP[16]
Marion	67	47	3	39.0%	58.8%	+19.8	C +20	County tally; on AP and DDHQ[24,25]
Tippah	39	31	0	25.3%	55.7%	+30.4	C +8	County tally; on DDHQ[23,25]
Benton	17	12	3	45.7%	58.6%	+12.9	C +5	AP; MFP count[16]
Alcorn	44	75	5	23.0%	37.0%	+14.0	H +31	MFP[16]
Itawamba	53	151	9	15.8%	26.0%	+10.2	H +98	MFP[16]
10 confirmed batches	**1,345**	**726**	**37**		**64.9%**		**C +619**	

County	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Colom share, county vote	Colom share, affidavits	Difference	Net	Source
Wilkinson*	107	33	1	70.1%	76.4%	+6.3	C +74	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]
Holmes*	84	8	0	86.8%	91.3%	+4.5	C +76	AP batch[24]
Scott*	85	26	2	48.9%	76.6%	+27.7	C +59	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]
George*	31	69	10	17.2%	31.0%	+13.8	H +38	DDHQ batch[25]
Choctaw*	20	21	1	34.3%	48.8%	+14.5	H +1	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]

"Colom share" is his share of the two-party vote. The county figure excludes the batch itself and comes from the AP and DDHQ feeds.[24,25] *Post-election batches the county has not labelled; their size and lean match affidavits. All 15 batches run more Colom than their county. None runs toward Hyde-Smith.

Hyde-Smith netted votes only in Alcorn, Itawamba and George, counties Trump carried by 50 to 65 points in 2024,[28] and even there by less than her overall margin. The Mississippi Free Press noted that across Alcorn, Chickasaw and Itawamba she netted just 71 votes "despite holding substantial overall leads in two of those counties."[16]

The pattern has a known cause. Mississippi moved more than 200,000 voters to inactive status before the election and requires inactive voters to vote by affidavit.[19,26] A DeSoto County commissioner said "more than half" of the affidavits she reviewed were from previously inactive voters who were reactivated and whose ballots will count.[11] Those voters are not a random sample of their county.

4. Late mail cannot close the gap, counting both kinds

Late mail comes in two pools. The Secretary of State's "outstanding" figure counts only the first: on Nov. 4 it described its count as ballots "that must be received within five business days."[31] Ballots already in a clerk's office but not yet counted are a second pool, not included in that figure.

a. Not yet returned

- **How many:** just under 2,900 mail ballots (2,857) were still outstanding Friday afternoon,[1] down from about 3,300 Thursday night.[2] These are ballots sent out and not yet received. Those postmarked by Election Day can arrive through 5 PM Tuesday, Nov. 10.
- **How many will arrive:** few. Hinds' certified 2024 results show 18 "5 Day Absentee" ballots[4] against 1,093 unreturned on the Secretary of State's Nov. 4, 2024 absentee report,[27] under 2%. Even at ten times that rate, this pool adds a few hundred votes statewide.
- **Where they are:** the Secretary of State has not published a county breakdown of the 2,857. Its last county-level report, from Nov. 2, showed 6,587 unreturned ballots, 43% of them in counties Hyde-Smith leads and 57% in counties Colom leads.[8] If the remaining ballots are spread the same way and split at county leans (AP feed),[24] all 2,857 arriving would net Colom about +300.
- **The ceiling, with no assumption about where they are:** if a quarter of the 2,857 arrived, more than ten times the only measured late-arrival rate we found (Hinds 2024: 18 of 1,093), and every one of them voted for Hyde-Smith, she would net about 714 votes,[1] roughly a quarter of the 2,574-vote lead.

b. Already received, not yet counted

This pool has two kinds of ballots: **late arrivals** that came in after the Nov. 2 report and have not been counted, and **on-time mail never entered**, received by Election Day but not yet added to the count. Harrison is the measured example of the second kind, and Rankin's 282 likely includes some. The statewide estimate below sizes only the late arrivals; the named counties cover the rest.

- **Named by the counties:** Jackson County Circuit Clerk Randy Carney said 280 absentee ballots have been received, with 138 still outstanding.[12] Rankin County received 282 mail-in absentee ballots that commissioners still need to process, per Circuit Clerk Michelle Adcock.[10] Hinds says its post-election work includes "eligible mail-in ballots received after Election Day";[6] it had 639 not returned on Nov. 2.[8] Rankin's 282 is more than the 206 it had not returned on Nov. 2,[8] so a county's uncounted mail can include ballots that arrived before that report.

- **Harrison:** Circuit Clerk Justin Wetzel said Nov. 4 that the county's mail-in absentees, processed on Election Day, were not entered before results were reported and "still must be added."[32] Harrison's totals on AP, on DDHQ and on the circuit clerk's own page are unchanged since 9:21 PM CST on election night,[24,25,32] so these ballots have not been added. No count has been published. AP's Harrison remainder of about 2,000 may include them. Harrison is close to even (Colom 48.1%), so even 1,300 such ballots at county shares move the margin by about 50 votes.[24]
- **Late arrivals, how many (counted by the state):** unreturned ballots fell from 6,587 on Nov. 2[8] to about 3,600 on Nov. 4,[31] about 3,300 on Nov. 5[2] and 2,857 on Nov. 6.[1] About 3,700 ballots therefore arrived after the Nov. 2 report. If the state measures from ballots sent rather than ballots requested (it has not said), the figure is about 3,300.[8]
- **Late arrivals, how many still uncounted (our estimate):** some of those ballots arrived by Election Day and were counted that night. No statewide figure says how many. Four counties publish absentee ballots cast by type, which can be set against what they had received by Nov. 2: Madison 5,796 v 5,764; Lauderdale 1,975 v 1,951; Lafayette 3,162 v 3,144; Pearl River 2,014 v 2,005.[8,33] Those 83 extra ballots are about a quarter of the roughly 350 arrivals these four counties' share of the statewide total implies, so about three quarters of their arrivals are still uncounted (60–81% by county). Applying 55–80% to the 3,300–3,700 arrivals gives roughly **1,800–3,000** ballots received but not yet counted. This is an estimate, not a count, and it likely runs low: the four counties all entered their mail on election night, while a county like Harrison has entered none of its mail.
- **Why the estimate does not decide anything:** four counties are a small sample, and a county like Rankin may handle its mail differently. The ceiling below does not use the four-county rate at all. It treats every one of the roughly 3,700 arrivals as uncounted, including all of Jackson's 280 and Rankin's 282, and puts them in the most Republican counties that had ballots out. Any real county's practice, Rankin's included, sits inside that worst case.
- **Where they are:** these ballots can only come from counties that had ballots out on Nov. 2. Spread like those ballots and split at county leans (AP feed),[8,24] 1,800–3,000 of them net Colom about +190 to +310. Jackson's 280 and Rankin's 282 at their own county leans net Hyde-Smith about 40 and 70.
- **The ceiling:** count all of the roughly 3,700 arrivals as uncounted, and place them in the most Republican counties first, up to each county's Nov. 2 unreturned count, and split each at its county's vote. Hyde-Smith nets about 600 at most, whatever the pool's size, because those counties had too few ballots out to supply more.[8,24] Harrison's on-time mail adds about 50 at most, since Harrison is close to even.

c. Both pools together

Both worst cases at once, which would need every not-yet-returned ballot that arrives to go to Hyde-Smith *and* every arrived ballot to sit in her strongest counties, net her about 1,350 votes, including Harrison's on-time mail, about half of the 2,574-vote lead. The two ceilings also overlap, since a ballot cannot be in both pools. At county leans, the two pools together most likely net Colom a few hundred. The simulation in Section 5 includes both, with Jackson's and Rankin's ballots as named blocks.

5. Hyde-Smith's path, tested

With about 30,300 votes left[24] and Pinkins taking about 2%, Hyde-Smith needs **54.3% of the two-party remainder**. In the affidavit batches so far (Section 3) she has won 35%. She has exceeded 54% only in Alcorn (63%), Itawamba (74%) and George (69%), three small counties that together hold under 500 of the remaining votes.[24]

What would have to be true for Hyde-Smith to win

The table comes from a county-by-county simulation (200,000 draws) of every outstanding pool: each county's measured or estimated affidavit count, acceptance rates centred on the measured county and Secretary of State figures,[1,10,16,20] late mail of both kinds (not yet returned, and received but not yet counted),[1,8,31] and named blocks such as the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees (included even though they may already be counted, which favors Hyde-Smith), and Jackson's and Rankin's received mail.[10,12,29] Each row changes one thing: how the remaining affidavits lean compared with their own county. The fourth column reruns each row with the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees treated as already counted (Section 2), which removes about 3,850 ballots that favor Hyde-Smith. The last column says whether any of the 15 reported batches (Section 3) has behaved that way.

If the remaining affidavits…	Colom wins	Final margin, median (10–90%)	If the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees are already counted: Colom wins, median margin	Seen in any county so far?
…lean toward Colom as the reported batches have (about 10–20 points more than their county)	>99.9%	+0.86 (+0.68 to +1.08)	>99.9%, +0.94	Yes, in 15 of 15 batches
…have no lean at all, and vote exactly like each county's counted vote	**99.7%**	+0.36 (+0.20 to +0.55)	**>99.9%**, +0.45	No. Every batch leaned more to Colom than its county, by 4 to 30 points

If the remaining affidavits…	Colom wins	Final margin, median (10–90%)	If the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees are already counted: Colom wins, median margin	Seen in any county so far?
…have no lean, and acceptance runs high (about 79%)	99.5%	+0.38 (+0.19 to +0.59)	99.9%, +0.46	No, same as above
…lean about 12 points *toward Hyde-Smith* compared with their own county, in every county, with high acceptance	42%	–0.03 (–0.22 to +0.17)	65%, +0.06	**No. This is the reverse of every batch reported.** It is shown only to mark where her path would begin.

Read the last row as a boundary, not a scenario. To reach even odds, Hyde-Smith needs affidavit voters statewide to be markedly more Republican than the counties they live in. Fifteen counties have reported, across every region of the state and every partisan lean, and all fifteen went the other way. If the Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees are already counted, even that boundary row gives Colom 65%. The conservative case is the second row, no affidavit lean at all, and it is not close either way.

6. Hinds County: AP's 7% outstanding is very likely too high, and it does not matter for the call

AP shows Hinds at 93% reporting: 77,465 counted against 83,296 expected, so about 5,800 out. AP's expected-vote parameters for Hinds are 74,951 Election Day in-person, 8,083 advance or absentee, and only 262 provisional.[24] In other words, AP's remainder assumes thousands of *regular* ballots are still uncounted, and almost no affidavits. The county's records point the other way on both.

a. The precinct data show absentees are already counted

Hinds' 2024 certified precinct report splits every precinct into Election Day and absentee votes.[4] Absentee shares ranged from 1.6% to 31.5%. If 2026 absentees were missing from the election-night report,[3] precincts heavy with absentee voters would look badly short against 2024. They do not:

2024 absentee share of precinct	Precincts	2024 total	2026 counted	2026 as % of 2024	Expected if absentees missing
1.6–7.7%	22	7,013	6,099	87%	98%
7.7–10.0%	21	13,113	11,955	91%	94%
10.0–11.9%	21	15,584	13,344	86%	92%

2024 absentee share of precinct	Precincts	2024 total	2026 counted	2026 as % of 2024	Expected if absentees missing
11.9–15.1%	21	16,736	14,962	89%	89%
15.1–31.5%	22	34,457	30,460	88%	82%

Turnout relative to 2024 is flat at 86–91% in every group. That is what counted absentees look like. Missing absentees would show as a steady decline down the table. Raymond 1, the most absentee-heavy precinct (31.5% in 2024), stands at 81% of its 2024 turnout; for its absentees to be uncounted, its 2026 Election Day turnout would have to exceed the 2024 presidential election by 18%. A regression across all 107 matched precincts, controlling for partisanship, puts the share of 2026 absentees already counted at 100% (90% interval 84–123%).

b. State rule: absentee scanning starts the moment polls close

> *"After the close of the polls at 7:00 p.m., the Resolution Board will open the ballot box containing the accepted absentee ballots … and shall immediately begin processing the accepted ballots through the central scanner. … The totals shall then be combined with the precinct tabulation totals for the unofficial vote count."*

Mississippi Administrative Code, Secretary of State Rule 731c, Part 17 Rule 3.2 (e)–(f).[5] Envelope review may begin when the polls open (3.2(a)). The rule also lets the board "recess as necessary and resume" before certification (3.2(g)), so it sets the expected practice rather than compelling it. The precinct data are the evidence that Hinds followed it this year.

c. The county described its post-election work as late mail and unreadable ballots

> *"The Hinds County Resolution Board began reviewing and processing absentee ballots at noon Nov. 4. That process includes eligible mail-in ballots received after Election Day, as well as ballots that cannot be properly read by scanning equipment."*

WLBT, Nov. 4, 2026, reporting the Hinds County Election Commission's statement through board attorney Tony Gaylor.[6] Hinds had 8,070 absentees returned by Nov. 2 and 639 not returned;[8] mail "received after Election Day" can only come from the latter.

d. What is actually left in Hinds

Affidavits, which the county has not yet released. Commissioners have given counts for three of five districts: about 650 in District 5, 387 in District 3, and 136 from 5 of District 4's 14 precincts.[7] Scaled to all five districts, that is roughly 2,300 cast. District 1 Commissioner Kidada Brown has said the county will not "turn a number in until everyone is complete."[7] At the acceptance rates seen elsewhere, Hinds' affidavits yield about

1,300–1,800 votes. Add Hinds' late mail, which cannot exceed the 639 ballots it had not returned on Nov. 2,[8] and the realistic remainder is 1,500–2,500, not 5,800. It is also far more than the 262 provisionals in AP's Hinds parameters.

e. Why the higher estimate is understandable

- **2023 precedent.** On election night in the 2023 governor's race, Hinds reported only 447 absentees and counted the rest the next day.[17] A model trained on that behavior would expect the same in 2026. The 2026 election-night report uses a different template with no vote-type columns, and the precinct test above shows the absentees are in.
- **The "exceeded 2020" statement.** The commission said preliminary figures indicated participation exceeded the November 2020 presidential election.[6] Hinds cast 100,944 ballots in 2020.[30] Even adding every absentee and affidavit to the current 77,465 would not reach that. The statement cannot be literal and should not be read as evidence of a large uncounted pool.
- **Turnout against the rest of the state.** Statewide, the 2026 count stands at 77.6% of the 2024 presidential vote.[24,28] Hinds is at 89.2%, right at the median for comparable Black-majority counties. Another 9,000 votes would put Hinds at 99.6% of its presidential-year turnout, the highest of all 82 counties.

f. Either way, Hinds helps only Colom

If AP's 5,800 were right[24] and split like the rest of Hinds (Colom 80–19), Colom's final margin would rise to roughly **+1.10 to +1.18 points**. If the county's own data are right, Hinds adds about 1,000–1,500 net for Colom. Neither scenario offers Hyde-Smith anything. A model that keeps the race uncalled because 7% of Hinds is outstanding is holding the call on votes that can only extend the leader's margin.

7. What comes next

Date (CST)	Event
Through the weekend	Rankin commissioners continue verifying affidavits; about half done, about 20% rejected so far[10]
Tue Nov. 10, 10 AM	Harrison County commission decides which of its 1,448 affidavits to accept[9]
Tue Nov. 10, 5 PM	Deadline for postmarked mail and ID cures. Rankin begins scanning affidavits[10]
Wed Nov. 11, 3 PM	DeSoto County holds its public review and count of about 2,100 affidavits[11]
Fri Nov. 13	County certification deadline[18]

What is uncertain, stated plainly

- **Acceptance rates vary.** Chickasaw 51%, Tippah 48%, Itawamba 66%, Rankin about 80% so far, Lowndes about 90%.[10,16] The large Republican-leaning pools (Rankin, Harrison, Jackson) have not finished. Lower acceptance shrinks both candidates' gains; it does not change direction.
- **The statewide affidavit total is not known.** Published estimates run from 12,000 to 20,000-plus.[19] Counted county figures already total about 15,800 in counties holding half the state's vote.[7,9,10,11,12,13,16,21] A larger pool helps Colom at the leans observed; a smaller pool leaves Hyde-Smith fewer votes to recover with.
- **Five of the 15 batches are unlabelled** (marked *). The ten confirmed batches tell the same story.
- **Cures.** Wrong-precinct affidavits cannot be cured.[10] Photo-ID affidavits and some voters registered through the Department of Public Safety can be. Cures can only raise acceptance, and the ID group is small: 365 of 21,421 affidavits in 2024.[20]
- **Hancock, Monroe and Tippah absentees.** County documents say about 3,850 absentees are not yet counted; turnout says they may already be in (Section 2). The report counts them as a Hyde-Smith gain. If that is wrong, it understates Colom by about 1,270.
- **Mail logging.** "Outstanding" means a ballot the state system has not marked as received. A county slow to log receipts would show ballots as outstanding that are already in its office. That moves ballots between the two late-mail pools in Section 4; it does not add to them.
- **Hinds' election-night practice in 2024 could not be checked** (no archived copy). The 2026 conclusion rests on the 2026 precinct data, the county's own description of its work, and the state rule.

Sources and documents

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Counts are from the AP and Decision Desk HQ results feeds, read at 6:45 PM CST Nov. 6, 2026. AP's remaining-vote figures are its published expected-vote parameters by county. The precinct comparison uses the Hinds County 2026 unofficial precinct report and 2024 certified precinct report (107 of 108 precincts matched; one precinct's line is unreadable in the county's PDF). The simulation draws affidavit counts, acceptance and lean per county with statewide shared shifts; its assumptions are stated in each table.